‘Your Excellency, since that is the case, I have only to wish you a very good evening.’[47]

The fight would cost Nott dear. Although he was by far the most popular, able and experienced general in the Army of the Indus, from this point on he came to have a reputation for being cantankerous with his superiors, and Auckland as well as Keane now believed him to be too difficult and undiplomatic ever to take full command. It was an impression that would lead to a further series of disastrous appointments, with Nott being passed over time and time again in favour of much less able men – something which would before long have fatal consequences for the occupation.

The Army of the Indus was now closing in on its first serious challenge: Kandahar. There were rumours that Barakzai cavalry units were in the vicinity, circling the army, ready to strike, and one night there was a false report of an imminent attack which caused the sleeping soldiers to rise in alarm from their tents and form up into defensive squares. They stayed there, muskets to the ready, until the break of dawn. Only the night-time diversion of a stream that was watering the camp, and the mysterious disappearance of Macnaghten’s two elephants, indicated that there were still unseen hostile forces round about, waiting for their opportunity.

It was just as well for the invaders that the Afghans did not attack with full force for the army was more or less broken by the journey they had just undergone through the passes. ‘We were at this time utterly unfit for active warfare,’ noted Thomas Gaisford in his journal. ‘Every man was greatly in need of repose and the horses could scarcely have crawled another march. As for the followers they were nearly starved. Our Commissariat supplies were quite exhausted. Indeed we were in a sorry plight for an advancing army.’[48]

Then around 10 a.m. on 20 April, the Army of the Indus had its first real break. A messenger arrived at the tent of Burnes’s intelligence chief, Mohan Lal Kashmiri, announcing that one of Dost Mohammad’s most prominent nobles was waiting beyond the camp with 200 followers, ready to offer his allegiance to Shah Shuja.[49] At last one of the letters sent by the Shah had borne fruit.[50] Mohan Lal was sent out to escort the nobleman in and to conduct him to the tent of the Shah.